into the new Burmese Buddhist culture, even though they have retained their own language.

The northern Pyu city states seem to have been ethnically related to the wider Burmese–Tibetan group, possibly indicating that they were migrants from Tibet, a characteristic shared with the later Burmese migrants. Indeed, the Pyu and the Burmese languages appear to have similar linguistic roots,[10] especially when compared to the differences between Mon and Burmese. As in southern Burma, the earliest religions in the region dominated by the Pyu were a mix of animist, Hindu and Buddhist, with the latter growing in relative importance over time. Buddhism was first recorded from around 500 AD. The Pyu occupied a region that also sat astride an important trade route between India and China and this may have given them access to wealth and exposure to external influences, but it also left them vulnerable to their more powerful neighbours.[11] The Pyu city states eventually fell after being weakened in a series of wars with the Chinese in the ninth century AD, leading to an incursion from Tibet of Burmese tribes taking advantage of ethnic ties and the weakening of the Pyu. The evidence for this period is partial and complicated, but one plausible explanation for this incursion is that the northernmost Pyu cities were already inhabited by people of Burman ethnicity as early as 900 AD.[12] In effect, this was less a process of conquest from Tibet and more one of two closely related groups intermingling as their relative power shifted.

In the ninth century these minor cities coalesced into the Pagan Kingdom,[13] during which time the Burmese peoples spread along the Irrawaddy Valley following the collapse of the Pyu city states. Burmese language and culture absorbed local influences from India and from the Mon in particular, but also derived linguistic and cultural elements from the wider region, from neighbouring states, and traders and settlers.[14]

Arakan

The earliest settlers in Arakan were probably closely related to aboriginal cultures that existed across South East Asia, Indonesia and Australia.[15] However, the earliest settled kingdoms that left an archaeological record were Indo–Aryan groups who arrived from the Ganges Valley as early as 3000 BC.[16] At the time of their arrival, minorities such as the Mru, Sak,